

Session 12: Prophetic Song

Key Takeaways

- The Torah's poetry often conveys the heart of its theology.
- The major themes in Exodus are all expressed in the Song of the Sea.
- Miriam, the prophetess, becomes a prominent witness of God's actions that save Israel.

The Literary Function of the Song of the Sea

Like liturgy, songs make history memorable. The people are not jubilant about their escape until a body of water stands between them and slavery. The people do not rejoice until their oppressors are brought to justice. Freedom is not enough on its own. As long as the possibility of re-enslavement remains, freedom is incomplete. The Song of the Sea celebrates justice, and it shows us how the Torah's poetry often conveys the heart of its theology.

The Themes of the Song of the Sea

Victory

- YHWH struck the gods of Egypt ([Exod. 15:1-12](#); cf. [Exod. 12:12-13](#)).
- "Who among the gods is like you, LORD? Who is like you—majestic in holiness, awesome in glory, working wonders?" ([Exod. 15:11](#))
- He turns to stubble the army that demanded stubble ([Exod. 15:7](#); cf. [5:12](#)).

Renown

YHWH's deliverance establishes his reputation among the nations; Philistia, Edom, Moab, and Canaan tremble ([Exod. 15:14-16](#)).

Creation

- YHWH's deliverance creates Israel as a new nation and dismantles Egypt.
- The "deeps" cover the Egyptian army ([Exod. 15:5](#); cf. [Gen. 1:2](#)).
- The Israelites walk through on "dry ground" ([Exod. 15:19](#); cf. [Gen. 1:9-10](#)).

Rest

- YHWH's deliverance culminates in proximity to his presence in the land.
- YHWH will "bring them in and plant them on the mountain of your inheritance" ([Exod. 15:17](#)).

The Literary Function of Miriam the Prophet

Miriam witnessed Moses' rescue from death in the River of Reeds (Exod. 2:4). Though only a child, Miriam brought women together to participate in redemption (Exod. 2:7-8).

Miriam witnessed Israel's rescue from death in the Sea of Reeds. Now a grown woman, Miriam brings together the women to celebrate redemption (Exod. 15:20-21).

Miriam's participation links these two redemption stories and reminds us of how many times God used women to accomplish his purposes. Shiphrah, Puah, the daughter of Levi, the daughter of Pharaoh, the maidservants, Zipporah, the women who plundered Egypt, and now the women who celebrate what God accomplished.

Her song echoes the theme of the plague narratives—that you may know that I am YHWH—by announcing its fulfillment—sing to YHWH for he is highly exalted. As a previous Pharaoh had mandated that the Israelites hurl their sons into the river, now YHWH hurls Pharaoh's warriors into the sea.

Reflection Question

What themes from the earlier parts of the book of Exodus do you see expressed in the Song of the Sea (Exod. 15:1-18)?